Jiayi Zhang

Email: jiayizhang@g.ucla.edu · Website: jiayizhang-k.github.io

EDUCATION

University of California, Los Angeles Expected June 2027
M.A., East Asian Studies; Digital Humanities Graduate Certificate. GPA: 3.97
Thesis: "Alternative Histories, Forbidden Futures: Time Travel Narratives and the Politics of Historical Imagination in Chinese Popular Culture"

Brandeis University May 2024
B.A., Psychology, Philosophy, International and Global Studies, *Summa Cum Laude*. GPA: 3.93
Thesis: "How We Reconcile with the Past: National Narrative and Individual Consciousness in Post-Mao China" doi:10.48617/etd.1131

RESEARCH INTERESTS

Cultural Sociology; Collective Memory; State and Popular Narratives; Culture and Cognition; Media, Arts, and Digital Culture; Reception and Meaning-Making; Computational Text Analysis; Contemporary China

PUBLICATION

Zhang, Jiayi, and Chandler Rosenberger. 2026. "Mapping China's Memories: Contested Histories and National Narratives in Social Media Reviews of Post-Mao Films." *International Journal of Politics, Culture, and Society*. doi:10.1007/s10767-026-09590-4

WORKS IN PROGRESS

Zhang, Jiayi. "Seeking Out the Banned Past: A Community of Viewers and the Memory of Maoism in Online Commentary on *The Blue Kite*" *(in preparation for submission)*

Zhang, Jiayi. "Copresence across Time: Culture and Interaction in Online Commentary on a Chinese Time-Travel Drama" *(analysis stage)*

Zhang, Jiayi, and Chandler Rosenberger. "The Contested Afterlife of Lu Xun: State Canonization, Museum Commemoration, and Popular Reception in Contemporary China" *(analysis stage)*

CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

"Mapping China's Memories: Contested Histories and National Narratives in Social Media Reviews of Post-Mao Films"
2026 American Sociological Association Annual Meeting, Student Forum Special Topic Paper Session. New York City.

"The Stories We Tell Ourselves: Mapping Cultural Memory in Post-Mao Chinese Film Discourse"
2026 Global Exchanges in Digital Humanities: Views from UCLA & Korea University. UCLA.

"How Did We Become Who We Are? What Online Movie Reviews Reveal About China's Struggle to Understand Its Past" (with Chandler Rosenberger)
2025 Colloquium on Culture and Identity in East Asia: New Digital Methods (co-organizer). Mandel Center for the Humanities, Brandeis University.

INVITED TALKS

"Computational Text Analysis and Collective Memory on Chinese Social Media"
Guest Lecture, Digital Humanities 120: Social Media Data Analytics, UCLA, Fall 2026

"Reversing the Verdict: Contested Interpretations of Emperor Yongzheng in Chinese Popular Culture"
Guest Lecture, History 19: Chinese History Through Historical Drama, UCLA, Fall 2026

"Beyond Linear History: *Scarlet Heart* and Temporal Imagination in Contemporary China"
Guest Lecture, Near Eastern Languages and Cultures 65: Global Time Travel, UCLA, Spring 2026

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Mapping China's Memories Project, Brandeis University Sept. 2023 – July 2026

- Co-awardee of a Mandel Center for the Humanities research grant with PI Chandler Rosenberger to investigate patterns of thought in cultural narratives of history and their role in shaping collective memory, identity, and political legitimacy.
- Applied natural language processing methods to online reviews of fifth-generation Chinese films.
- Expanded the project from an undergraduate thesis into a co-authored, peer-reviewed article (2026).

Research Assistant, Brandeis University, Sociology Department Dec. 2022 – Aug. 2024; June 2026

- Studied how official rhetoric shapes public engagement on Chinese social media (WeChat, Weibo), applying computational text analysis to discourse and collective memory.
- Co-developed a study of Lu Xun's legacy, conducting close readings of the Shanghai Lu Xun Museum's exhibition materials and tour narrative.

Intern and Field Researcher, Shanghai Lu Xun Museum Summer 2023

- Researched Lu Xun's legacy as a literary and cultural icon of modern China, producing materials on national memory and identity.
- Observed and engaged with audiences through tours and public programs, analyzing how the museum presents history to diverse publics, including school groups and cultural organizations.

AWARDS, FELLOWSHIPS, AND GRANTS

University Fellowship, Division of Graduate Education, UCLA 2024–2025
Research Grant (Co-Awardee), Mandel Center for the Humanities, Brandeis University 2023–2024
Provost's Undergraduate Research Fellowship ($5,000), Brandeis University 2023

TEACHING

Co-Instructor, Sociology 111A: Cognitive Sociology, Brandeis University Summer 2026

- Co-designed the syllabus; taught the course's computational text analysis component; guided students through weekly analyses and final research projects.

Teaching Assistant, Digital Humanities 120: Social Media Data Analytics, UCLA Fall 2025, Fall 2026

- Led lab sections teaching computational text analysis in Python, guiding students from research design through data collection, analysis, and interpretation.

Teaching Assistant, Bioengineering 165EW: Bioengineering Ethics, UCLA Winter 2026

- Led weekly discussion sections on technology, ethics, and society; supported students' analytical writing in a writing-intensive course.

SKILLS

Methods: Computational text analysis (seeded topic modeling, word embeddings, sentiment analysis); web scraping; social network analysis; in-depth interviews and fieldwork
Programming: R, Python
Visualization & GIS: Tableau, Datawrapper, ArcGIS, Gephi
Languages: Mandarin Chinese (native), English (fluent)

SERVICE AND ACTIVITIES

Student Assistant, Modern Endangered Archives Program (MEAP), UCLA Library 2025
Editor, *Simpliciter: Brandeis Undergraduate Philosophy Journal* 2024
Undergraduate Peer Research Mentor, Brandeis University 2023–2024
Undergraduate Department Representative, International and Global Studies, Brandeis University 2023–2024
Varsity Athlete, NCAA Division III Women's Tennis, Brandeis University 2021–2024